But what was an Indian company? In Krishna Aiyangar's understanding, an Indian shipping company was one where its directors and shareholders were Indians and managed 'as far as possible by Indians'. When committee members tried to corner him by asking if experience was not a prerequisite for expert management, Krishna Aiyangar snapped back that experience flowed from training. 'Necessity is the mother of invention; when we are to face a situation, we naturally have a tendency to look closely into the matter and we learn much more than what other people would learn under ordinary circumstances.'[39]

After the consideration of these big questions, the committee now directly confronted him on the failure of SSNCo. Krishna Aiyangar held that, 'For two or three years it was running quite satisfactorily' and would have 'flourished but for the unfair competition of the B.I.S.N. line'. BI, he said, did not stop with reducing their rates, sometimes offering free passage, and even free inducements. The Swadeshi company stood no chance. Krishna Aiyangar vociferously denied that the company was liquidated because of lack of capital.[40]

To the question if starting an enterprise without adequate capital was prudent, Krishna Aiyangar saw behind this a desire to pre-empt any competition to BI's monopoly. How would anyone invest when there were no steamers to show, he asked and pointed out that Rs 10 lakh (here he was somewhat exaggerating) had been raised: 'If we have the same spirit everywhere as we have in Tuticorin, there would not be any difficulty,' he asserted hopefully.[41]

As chair of the committee, Froom had the final word. Quoting from SSNCo's annual report of 1908–09, he pinned down Krishna Aiyangar on some specifics. Evidently, he had done his homework, digging up the necessary documents. Goliath was leaving nothing to chance. Froom's line of questioning can only be described as vindictive. Krishna Aiyangar was left without any defence when cornered on the disastrous move to charter the Shah Line Company's *Ipswich*, a decision Froom attributed to inexperience and mismanagement.